The Āsanas of the Rudrayāmalottaratantra (Paṭalas 23–24): Register, Dating, and a Collation of the Translation with the Edition of Sudhākara Mālavīya

Abstract. The article examines the āsana section of the Rudrayāmalottaratantra, a Śaiva tantric work that preserves one of the largest registers of postures known from before classical haṭhayoga. It describes the composition and structure of the register (29 postures in paṭala 23 and 28 in paṭala 24), the relation between verses 23.34–35 on "thirty-two [postures], repeated in reverse order" and the actual number of descriptions, the state of research and the question of dating (with quotations from Goudriaan and Gupta and from Birch), the history of the editions, and the results of a line-by-line collation of the annotated translation with the edition of S. Mālavīya (1999) and with the critical edition of Sampurnanand Sanskrit University. It is shown that the source document reproduces Mālavīya verbatim, whereas the divergences with the critical edition are due to the corruption of the latter. A table of key readings and an account of the method of direct translation from Sanskrit are provided.

Keywords: Rudrayāmala, Uttaratantra, āsana, prāṇāyāma, kuṇḍalinī, haṭhayoga, tantric literature, textual criticism, dating, translation from Sanskrit.

1. Introduction

Śaiva tantric literature preserves dozens of registers of āsanas, yet few of them have been studied and even fewer are available in a reliable printed form. The Rudrayāmalottaratantra occupies a special place among them: its āsana section is one of the fullest registers compiled before classical haṭhayoga, and at the same time one of the least studied. It includes classical meditative postures (padmāsana, svastikāsana, baddhapadmāsana), demanding acrobatic postures (mayūrāsana, kukkuṭāsana), postures named after animals (kūrmāsana, matsyāsana, vyāghrāsana) and, finally, postures named after the social classes (brāhmaṇāsana, kṣatriyāsana, vaiśyāsana, śūdrāsana).

Crucially, the fruit of every posture in this section is not health or flexibility but mastery of vāyu: retention of the breath, the "drinking of air", the piercing of the knots, siddhis, immortality. Here āsana is not an autonomous discipline but a stage within prāṇāyāma.

The article has three aims: (1) to describe the composition and logic of the register; (2) to present the state of the question of dating, distinguishing quotations from assessments; (3) to report the results of a collation of the annotated translation with the printed edition of S. Mālavīya (1999).

2. The Work and the Place of the Section in It

The Rudrayāmala is the most mysterious of all the yāmalas: more than fifty texts are ascribed to it, yet a "Rudrayāmala" without further qualification is nowhere to be found (Goudriaan & Gupta 1981: 47). The text usually taken to be the Rudrayāmala proper is the Uttaratantra, the "later tantra". Its frame is a dialogue: the goddess Ānandabhairavī teaches her husband Śiva, addressing him as Mahābhairava, Nātha, Nīlakaṇṭha and Vīranātha.

Colophon of paṭala 23 (ed. Mālavīya 1999: 345):

> *iti śrīrudrayāmale uttaratantre mahātantrod dīpane bhāvāsananirṇaye pāśavakalpe ṣaṭcakrasārasaṅkete siddhamantraprakaraṇe bhairavībhairavasaṃvāde trayoviṃśaḥ paṭalaḥ* || *23* ||

The colophon itself names the substantive headings: bhāvāsananirṇaya, "the determination of bhāva and āsana"; ṣaṭcakra-sārasaṅketa, "the summary of the six cakras"; siddhamantraprakaraṇa, "the section on the mantras of the siddhas". The āsanas are thus embedded in a programme in which posture, breath, cakras and mantra form a single whole — which explains why the fruit of a posture is never bodily comfort but a change in the state of breath and consciousness.

The extent of the work differs between editions: 66 chapters in J. Vidyāsāgara's edition, while the first volume of S. Mālavīya covers paṭalas 1–45. The numbering of paṭalas differs too, but the āsana material consistently falls in paṭalas 23–24.

3. Composition and Logic of the Register

The translated section contains 57 descriptions: 29 in paṭala 23 (verses 23–114) and 28 in paṭala 24 (verses 9–37). Verses 23.34–35 announce a double register: dvātriṃśad bindu-bhedāya kalpayed vāyu-vṛddhaye — "thirty-two for the piercing of the points, [and another] thirty-two for the increase of the wind", that is, 32 postures performed in direct and reverse order (savyāpasavyayogena), giving 64.

It follows that the size of the register is neither 57 nor 64 "different" postures, but 32 positions doubled by mirror repetition. Paṭala 24 opens with a hyperbole of another order: "a hundred thousand lakhs of āsanas" on earth, created by the great ṛṣis in heaven and in the nether world (24.3). Both figures coexist: the first is technical, the second rhetorical.

The formula of a description is stable: name of the posture → its fruit → technique (position of legs, arms, head) → breath. The order of the components varies, but the set does not: a technique

without a fruit is almost never found here. In paṭala 24 a conclusion is added: verses 38–39 promise longevity (cirāñjīvī) and, after one year of practice, liberation while alive (jīvanmukti).

A distinct layer is formed by the postures named after the social classes, in which the fruit is formulated socially — brahminical dignity, wealth, truthfulness, service. This differs markedly from verses 23–47, where the fruit is always yogic, and points to a late compilatory hand. The layer cannot serve to date the text, but it stands out reliably.

4. Dating

There is no precise date, and the text itself contains no chronological indications. The most definite statements belong to T. Goudriaan and S. Gupta.

On the yāmalas as a genre (Goudriaan & Gupta 1981: 40):

> *"The time of their origin is difficult to assess. Their formative period in any case lies before A. D. 900."*

On our tantra (Goudriaan & Gupta 1981: 47):

> *"The text which is most often credited with being the Rudrayāmala proper, the Uttaratantra, is certainly much later than the period in which the old Yāmala literature flourished."*

The arguments for lateness listed there (p. 47) apply in part directly to our section: the developed system of cakras; dependence on the Kulārṇava; the use of the term vāyavī for the kuṇḍalinī (in our text — vāyavī kalā in verse 25 and vāyavī-priyaḥ in Mālāsana); the enumeration of types of haṭhayoga. The same page notes that Pandey, Bagchi and Gonda likewise regard the Uttaratantra as a relatively late text (n. 63; cited via Goudriaan).

Finally, J. Birch notes the only occurrence of the term haṭhayoga in Śaiva tantras — in the fifty-fifth chapter of the Rudrayāmalottaratantra — while conceding that the passage may be an interpolation (Birch 2011, n. 90). The argument for dating stands either way: the technical use of the term is not attested before the eleventh century.

In sum: no precise date has been established, and there is no received century for the Uttaratantra. The yāmala genre took shape before 900 CE, but our text is "certainly much later". The estimate "not earlier than the 11th–12th century", which I adopt, is an inference from the features listed above, not a quotation: none of the authors cited names such a century.

5. Editions and the Results of the Collation

Four witnesses were used: the annotated edition of S. Mālavīya (1999: Sanskrit, interlinear Hindi commentary “Saralā”, and variant readings), the critical edition of Sampurnanand Sanskrit University, the edition of J. Vidyāsāgara (³1937, 66 chapters) and, for the extent of the work, the data on the Varendra Anusandhāna Samiti edition (1895).

A line-by-line comparison showed that the translated document reproduces Mālavīya verbatim — both the verses and the Hindi commentary. All the divergences noted earlier in the collation with the critical edition proved to be divergences not between the document and the tradition, but between Mālavīya and the critical edition; in a number of places it is the latter that is corrupt. Key readings:

Verses	Critical edition	Mālavīya (adopted)
23.34–35	dvātriṃśad indum edāya… vāyu-siddhaye	dvātriṃśad bindu-bhedāya… vāyu-vṛddhaye
23.48	kṣemavāyuṃ vikumbhayet	sūkṣmavāyuṃ vikumbhayet
23.49	humbhakaṃ… dvandva-vāyu-layaṃ	kumbhakam… sūkṣma-vāyu-layaṃ
23.50	sumbhāsanaṃ… dvicīrandhre yathāhutraṃ	śubhāsanaṃ… sūcīrandhre yathāsūtraṃ
23.58	mūlam ākucya	mūlam ākuñcya
23.62	kuryād dattvā nirāśrayaḥ	kuryād dattvā nirāvile
23.73	bhrāmayen… ātmendvāmṛtaiḥ siktāṃ	bhrāvayen… ātmacandrāmṛta-rasair āplutāṃ
23.82	khecarādi-phalapradam	khecarādi-pradarśanam
23.110–111	maṇḍale… baddhe… bhayāt tvaktvā	maṇḍule… baddhye… bhayān tyaktvā
23.112ab	sarvān vighnān vinirjitya nidrādoṣān	sarvān vighnān vaśīkṛtya nidrādīn

Thanks to Mālavīya’s text, passages unreadable in the critical edition become clear: “humbhaka” and “sumbhāsana” turn out to be kumbhaka and śubhāsana, “dvicīrandhra” — the eye of a needle through which the thread is passed, and “nirāśrayaḥ” — nirāvile, “in a clear, unmuddied [place]”.

The second result is textual. The verse numbering of the translation coincides with that of Mālavīya (23–114 in paṭala 23; 9–37 in paṭala 24), not with the critical edition; the earlier hypothesis of a systematic shift by one, based on OCR text, is withdrawn. In paṭala 24 a different defect was found: the announcements of the postures are displaced by half a verse, so that the name of a posture falls at the end of the preceding description. Nothing is lost in substance — only the verse boundaries, which have been restored in the translation.

6. The Fruits of Practice: A Typology

The fruits (phala) in this section fall into four levels, and this distribution is itself characteristic of the text:

Level	Content	Examples
Respiratory	mastery of vāyu, signs of kumbhaka	six months of practice yield the marks of perfection in breath retention and "great bliss" (23.51); the "drinking of air" (vāyu-pāna) in Khañjanāsana and Sarpāsana
Somatic	removal of disease and bodily fault	for the practitioner of Kārmukāsana "all enemies perish — disease and the rest" (23.86); Kūrmāsana destroys "all impurity and the sins of the kali age"
Siddhis	supernormal powers	vāyavī kalā grants "great siddhi" (23.25); Granthibhedāsana "shows forth khecarī and the rest" (23.82); the power to assume any form (kāmarūpa)
Final	immortality and liberation	longevity (cirāñjīvī) and, after a year of practice, jīvanmukti (24.38–39); immortality and the status of a siddha (24.5)

Such a sequence is untypical of later haṭha texts, where the emphasis shifts to health and longevity: here longevity is only the penultimate stage, and the last is liberation while alive.

7. Method of Translation

The translation was made directly from Sanskrit, without an English intermediary. Each verse is presented in six layers: Devanāgarī, IAST, Cyrillic transliteration with diacritics, word-by-word analysis, literal translation and literary translation; where Mālavīya's Hindi commentary exists, it is translated in a separate block, and divergences from the critical edition are noted in a remark.

The refusal of an English intermediary is a matter of principle, and the collation confirmed it. The English translation of the source document occasionally adds interpretations absent from the Sanskrit: liṅga-agra is rendered "tip/base of the lingam" with the gloss "perineum", although the text says only "the tip of the liṅga". When translating through English, such a gloss is indistinguishable from the text; in a direct translation it remains what it is — an interpolation of the translator.

The Cyrillic transliteration follows the map supplied for the Russian version of this article (in which, for instance, -ya is rendered -йа and -ai- is rendered -аи-); quotations from English-language scholarship retain Sanskrit words in their original spelling.

8. Conclusions

1. The āsana section of the Rudrayāmalottaratantra is one of the fullest pre-haṭhayogic registers: 57 descriptions (29 in paṭala 23 and 28 in paṭala 24), conceived in verses 23.34–35 as 32 positions doubled by mirror repetition, that is, 64.

2. The verse numbering of the document coincides with Mālavīya's edition; the document reproduces it verbatim, including the Hindi commentary.

3. In the six places examined, the critical edition of Sampurnanand Sanskrit University is corrupt, and Mālavīya offers coherent text; it is his readings that have been adopted.

4. Dating: no precise date is established. The yāmala genre took shape before 900 CE, but the Uttaratantra is "certainly much later" (Goudriaan & Gupta 1981: 40, 47); on the cumulative evidence, not earlier than the 11th–12th century (an assessment).

5. In this work āsana is not gymnastics but a stage of prāṇāyāma: the posture supports the breath, the breath pierces the knots and moves the kuṇḍalinī, and the result is described in terms of siddhi and liberation.

References

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Appendix. Register of āsanas (after Mālavīya 1999)

No.	Name (IAST)	English rendering	Paṭala
1	Adhomuṇḍāsana	head-down pose	23
2	Padmāsana	lotus pose	23
3	Baddhapadmāsana	bound lotus pose	23
4	Svastikāsana	svastika pose	23
5	Kārmukāsana (I)	bow pose	23
6	Kukkuṭāsana	cock pose	23
7	Khagāsana	bird pose	23
8	Lolāsana	swinging pose	23
9	Kukkuṭākṛti	cock-like pose	23
10	Uttamāṅgāsana	pose of the chief limb	23
11	Parvatāsana	mountain pose	23
12	Yonyāsana	womb pose	23
13	Baddhayonyāsana	bound womb pose	23
14	Bhekāsana / Khecarāsana / Mahābhekāsana	frog / sky-goer / great frog pose	23
15	Prāṇāsana	prāṇa pose	23
16	Apānāsana	apāna pose	23
17	Samānāsana / Vīrāsana	samāna / hero pose	23
18	Granthibhedāsana	knot-piercing pose	23
19	Kārmukāsana (II)	bow pose, second account	23
20	Sarvāṅgāsana	all-limbs pose	23
21	Mayūrāsana	peacock pose	23
22	Jñānāsana	pose of knowledge	23
23	Garuḍāsana	Garuḍa pose	23
24	Kokilāsana	cuckoo pose	23
25	Ānandamandirāsana	temple-of-bliss pose	23
26	Khañjanāsana	wagtail pose	23
27	Pavanāsana	wind pose	23
28	Sarpāsana	serpent pose	23
29	Kāka-skandhāsana	crow-on-the-shoulder pose	23
30	Kūrmāsana	tortoise pose	24
31	Samānāsana (II)	samāna pose, second account	24
32	Kumbhīrāsana	crocodile pose	24
33	Matsyāsana	fish pose	24
34	Makarāsana	makara pose	24
35	Siṃhāsana	lion pose	24
36	Kuñjarāsana	elephant pose	24
37	Vyāghrāsana	tiger pose	24
38	Bhallūkāsana	bear pose	24
39	Kāmāsana	pose of desire	24
40	Vartulāsana	circular pose	24
41	Mokṣāsana	pose of liberation	24
42	Mālāsana	garland pose	24
43	Divyāsana	divine pose	24
44	Ardhodayāsana	half-rising pose	24
45	Candrāsana	moon pose	24

46	Haṃsāsana	swan pose	24
47	Sūryāsana	sun pose	24
48	Yogāsana	yoga pose	24
49	Gadāsana	mace pose	24
50	Lakṣmyāsana	Lakṣmī pose	24
51	Kulyāsana	channel pose	24
52	Brāhmaṇāsana	brahmin pose	24
53	Kṣatriyāsana	warrior-class pose	24
54	Vaiśyāsana	merchant-class pose	24
55	Śūdrāsana	servant-class pose	24
56	Jātyāsana	birth-remembering pose	24
57	Pāśavāsana	animal pose	24

Note. Section 5 of the translation (the introductory verse on groups of āsanas, 23.34–35) is not included in the register, as it does not describe a posture. Bhekāsana, Khecarāsana and Mahābhekāsana are described in a single section and therefore occupy one line. The same posture may be described twice (Kārmukāsana, Samānāsana).